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An investigation of the practices of middle leaders in Australian schools

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Abstract

The role of middle leaders in Australian schools as influencers on classroom practice has been the focus of increased attention in recent years. Although there is recognition of the importance of middle leaders, there are gaps in what we understand about their practices and the nuances of practice that occur due to site-based conditions, or practice architectures, within each individual school context. This paper explores the self-reported practices of 25 middle leaders from a range of primary and secondary schools across Australia to deepen our understanding of how those practices are played out and how best to support the development of middle leaders. Analysis of data from in-depth interviews revealed the need to provide resources, conditions, and arrangements that are focused on what happens in classrooms, along with professional learning that is individualised and contextualised to assist the transition from teacher to leader of teaching and learning. Further, middle leaders require support from senior leaders that recognises the complex and hectic nature of middle leading.

Keywords Middle leadership · Practice architectures · Practices · Middle leading practices · Professional development

Introduction

The role of middle leaders (MLs) in Australian schools has increasingly become the focus of attention for schools and school systems in recent years (Drysdale & Gurr, 2017; Harris et al., 2024). This may be attributed to the acknowledgement

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of middle leading being critical to the continual improvement of teachers' classroom pedagogy (Australian Institute for Teaching & School Leadership, 2022; Grice, 2019; Gurr, 2019). For Australian MLs, the increased focus has resulted in the publication of formal middle leading standards by the Australian Institute for Teaching and School Leadership (AITSL) (2024) to bridge the gap between the existing standards for teachers and principals. The AITSL standards aim to assist MLs in developing knowledge, skills, and dispositions for middle leadership and future leadership roles. While AITSL have acknowledged that 'not all standards will apply to all middle leader roles' (p. 6), it can also be argued that a defined set of standards will not fully address the multifarious practices undertaken by MLs, nor can it capture the site-specific nuances that influence how middle leadership is defined and played out across primary and secondary schools and across a range of school systems.

The growing field of middle leadership is a part of a broader movement in research seeking to describe and delineate the different kinds of educational leadership in schools. For example, the systematic review of literature of teacher leadership (e.g., Schott et al., 2020; Wenner & Campbell, 2017) argued that since the school leadership literature is strongly associated with the leadership of principals there is a need to pay more attention to leadership of other educators in schools. This is necessary for providing a more comprehensive picture of school development. Wenner and Campbell (2017) and Schott et al. (2020) identified the usefulness of focusing on the leadership of 'regular' teachers who lead in and beyond the classroom whose primary tasks are comprised of classroom teaching but accompany other responsibilities, for example, leading the professional development of their colleagues. In this study, the term middle leadership rather than teacher leadership is used to give a stronger prominence to their positioning within the leadership structure of the school. There is acknowledgement in current literature that there are gaps in what we understand about the practices of MLs globally (Schott et al., 2020) and in Australia (Lipscombe et al., 2023), and while the roles of MLs have been articulated by various researchers (De Nobile, 2020; Gurr & Drysdale, 2013; Wattam, 2021; White, 2021), the models presented typically provide descriptions of characteristics, roles and responsibilities, with little or no direct reference to the leaders' actual practices (Tindall-Ford et al., 2024). Moreover, there is a lack of understanding of, if and how practices are aligned to the identified roles of MLs as articulated in existing literature.

This paper builds on preliminary findings from the first phase of a four-year study (Edwards-Groves et al., 2023; Grootenboer et al., 2023; Tindall-Ford et al., 2024) and focuses on the self-reported practices of Australian school MLs. The larger study examines middle leading practices and the 'flow of influence' of those practices on teacher development. Data informing this paper are drawn from semi-structured interviews conducted with 25 MLs from primary and secondary schools across Australia. The data were interrogated to gain an understanding of the MLs' self-reported practices. The research question was as follows:

What are the core practices that school MLs perceive they enact in their roles as leaders of curriculum and pedagogical development in their school sites?

The insights gained from this study aim to further contribute to current literature on ML practices and provide empirically informed implications for the support of MLs.

Middle leadership in Australian schools

It is acknowledged that middle leadership in education is difficult to define (Bassett, 2016). However, there is agreement amongst the literature that those in middle leadership positions work between different hierarchical levels, typically between teachers and senior leadership teams (Ainsworth et al., 2022; De Nobile, 2018; Grootenboer et al., 2015), and hold recognised management and leadership responsibilities. Their leadership responsibilities are more than those of a teacher, but distinctly different than those of the school principal (Gurr & Drysdale, 2021). Middle leading roles are varied, for example, heads of departments, subject leaders, pastoral-care leaders, and year-level coordinators (Brooks & Cavanagh, 2009; Hammersley-Fletcher & Kirkham, 2007). While there may not be consensus on a definition of middle leadership, there is agreement that MLs have significant influence on teaching practice and student learning (Bennett et al., 2007; Harris et al., 2019, 2024; Leithwood, 2016).

While there are MLs who do not retain formal teaching responsibilities (Harris et al., 2019; Li et al., 2018) this study focuses specifically on classroom-based MLs, that is, those who have both teaching responsibilities and leadership responsibilities (Grootenboer et al., 2023). We are concerned with these MLs because they each have a complex set of pressures and each address unique, site-based expectations and challenges that stem from the dual responsibilities of teaching and leading. Harris et al. (2019) discuss key tensions experienced by MLs, the first being the tension between expectations from those above the ML and the expectations they experience from their teams. The second tension articulated by Harris et al. (2019), being a tension from the role of line manager of team members while simultaneously needing to establish professional collegial relationships with team members. Those MLs who teach then have the added tension of competing teaching and leading responsibilities.

In their attempt to conceptualise MLs' role and tensions, Grootenboer et al. (2015) identify three characterising dimensions of middle leading:

> *1. Positional*—MLs are structurally and relationally situated 'between'the school senior management and the teaching staff. They are not in a peculiar space of their own, but are practicing members of both groups.
> *2. Philosophical*—MLs practice their leading from the centre or alongside their peers. In this sense they are not the 'heroic crusader' leading from the front, but rather alongside and in collaboration with their colleagues.
> *3. Practical*—middle leading is a practice and is understood and developed as a practice. To this end, the focus is on the sayings, doings, and relatings of leading rather than the characteristics and qualities of middle leadership (p. 17).

Middle leading practices

Arguably the role of MLs is increasing in complexity, and according to Ainsworth et al. (2022), models such as De Nobile's (2018) provide lists of roles and attributes that could be perceived as atomistic, resulting in a reductive view of MLs' roles and practices. Viewed in this way, such models could be viewed as a recipe approach to effective leadership (Gunter, 2013). However, it could also be argued that the development of such models assists MLs in understanding their roles and developing their practices. More recently there have been models of ML instructional practices informed by literature reviews (see Tang et al., 2022; Highfield & Rubie-Davies, 2022) that focus on MLs as developing and supporting others, creating conditions for individual and team success and leading, teaching and learning (Tindall-Ford et al., 2024). Grootenboer and colleagues configured middle leading practices according to three inter-related aspects: leading and teaching; managing and facilitating, and collaborating and communicating (Grootenboer et al., 2017) (see Table 1). These aspects represent key dimensions emerging from empirical international research conducted by Grootenboer et al. (2015) and confirmed more recently (Grootenboer et al., 2023). Further, the dimensions are also adopted by the Australian Institute of Teaching and School Leadership (2022). For the purpose of this article, the empirically informed three dimensions of middle leading practice will be used, however it is important to note that while they provide a structure to assist us in analysing practices, they are not intended as a comprehensive list or 'recipe book'.

Table 1 Dimensions of middle leading practice (Grootenboer et al., 2017)

Dimension	Practices
Leading and teaching	Leading by modelling exemplary teaching Sharing of teaching practice Engaging in the teaching practices of others Mediating between staff and senior leaders Balancing between tangible expectations and the freedom to innovate
Managing and facilitating	Facilitating professional development (of self and others) Administrative tasks Focusing development of educational issues to improve student learning
Collaborating and communicating	Developing a shared sense of purpose Engaging in professional dialogue Supporting teacher development through sustained support Creating and sustaining relational trust Developing and sustaining relationships 'up' and 'across' Creating 'space' for others to learn and communicative spaces

Middle leading and practice architectures

The understandings of middle leading here are informed by the Theory of Practice Architectures (TPA) (Kemmis et al., 2014). In simple terms, this sees leading practices as being made up of characteristic 'sayings, doings, and relatings' that are enabled and constrained by site-based conditions and arrangements—'practice architectures'. While there is not space here to give a full account of the TPA,[1] it is suffice to say that it is a site-ontological approach that focuses on the happening of practices as they unfold in time and space. Furthermore, the leading practices and other practices in a school's *practicescape* as referred to by Grootenboer and Edwards-Groves, (2024) that are possible, are pre-figured by the prevailing 'practice architectures' (colloquially described as 'conditions') in that site at that time. Thus, as Kemmis et al. (2014) proposed, if one wants to change and develop practices, then they need to attend to the practice architectures that enable and constrain the practices that exist in sites.

Methods

The qualitative data informing this paper are drawn from the second phase of a four-year project investigating the practices of MLs in Australian schools. To investigate the research question, an in-depth, semi-structured interview schedule was collaboratively developed by the researchers. The interview items focused on three dimensions of practice as defined by Grootenboer et al. (2017). These categories are 'reciprocally related and interconnected dimensions' (Grootenboer et al., 2023, p. 5) and emerged from a sustained body of international research on middle leading that resulted in the development of a middle leading practice model (Grootenboer et al., 2017). Fidelity to the practice-based approach was achieved in requiring participants to describe their practices and where possible, provide examples in accordance with the three dimensions. This provided a frame for the phenomenological interviews.

Participants

Thirty-two interviews were conducted via video-conferencing software (Zoom) over 18 months. Although all 32 participants identified as MLs, seven did not have a teaching role at that time and were excluded from the analysis in alignment with our definition of MLs as those who have formal leadership roles whilst retaining regular teaching commitments. The remaining 25 participants had varying leadership experience and represented a range of demographics and educational jurisdictions from New South Wales, Queensland, Western Australia, Victoria, and the Australian Capital Territory. The participants consisted of 19 females and six males, 10 of whom were based in primary schools and 15 from secondary schools. Participants

[1] For a more fulsome account of a practice understanding of middle leading, see Grootenboer, (2018)

were recruited using a snowballing technique and advertising through events such as online seminars for MLs, and through local networks and contacts. Ethics approval was granted from Griffith University Human Research Ethics Committee (Approval Number 2021/482). All data were de-identified prior to analysis and participants were allocated a pseudonym.

Data analysis

Interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim by professional transcribers. Initial analysis was conducted through a deductive approach to thematic analysis beginning with the pre-existing framing of the three practice dimensions detailed above (Table 1). The data were then coded recursively through a inductive-deductive approach to each dimension (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006), resulting in emergent themes within the dimensions: leading and teaching; managing and facilitating, and collaborating and communicating. It should also be noted that the reciprocal relationships across the dimensions caused the researchers to make decisions about where to position specific data. Indeed, to a greater or lesser degree, many aspects involved all of the practice dimensions, so they were coded against the most prominent or salient one.

Table 2 provides an overview of the themes that emerged along with the number of times the themes were coded and the number of participants the data were drawn from.

Findings

Analysis of the interviews with MLs reveal the complex and nuanced range of practices amongst participants that were shaped by the practice architectures within the school sites. The data also revealed their main leading practices, and these are now presented within the three dimensions of *leading and teaching, communicating and collaborating,* and *managing and facilitating.* In reporting these findings, we are intentionally providing an extended descriptive account of their practices in their own words. This is because currently there is little empirical evidence about what MLs actually do, and the conditions and arrangements (i.e., practice architectures) that shape their practices.

Leading and teaching

As mentioned earlier, the participants held both leadership and classroom teaching roles. Although participants were also asked about their personal teaching practices, these data are not included in the analysis. Data coded within this dimension of leadership practices link specifically to leadership of others that occurs within the classrooms of the MLs or those they were leading. As a result, two themes of *models* practice and *observes* practice emerged. Table 3 provides an exemplar excerpt for each theme.

Table 2 Overview of emergent themes

Dimension	Leading and teaching (n = 18, 11%)	Collaborating and communicating (n = 80, 47%)	Managing and facilitating (n = 71, 42%)
Categories	Models practice (n = 12, p = 11) Observes practice (n = 6, p = 5)	Collaborating Develops others (n = 15, p = 7) Builds & maintains teams (n = 15, p = 11) Recognises & uses others' strengths (n = 10, p = 7) Communicating: Communicates (n = 16, p = 11 Leads informally (n = 14, p = 11) Provides & seeks feedback (n = 6, p = 6) Translates (n = 4, p = 4)	Managing: Administrates (n = 10, p = 7) Manages people (n = 8, p = 8) Manages time (n = 7, p = 6) Manages tasks (n = 5, p = 5) Manages data (n = 3, p = 3) Manages teaching & learning programs (n = 4, p = 4) Manages resources (n = 2, p = 2) Facilitating: Facilitates PL for others (n = 22, p = 9) Organises PL for self (n = 10, p = 5)

n number of items coded

p number of participants coded

Table 3 Leading and teaching data excerpts

Theme	Excerpt
Models Practice	Being a role model is the best – like I model how I expect my staff to carry themselves, whether it be the way they talk to students, whether it be the way they approach their teaching in the classroom. I'm very big on high expectations so I really see myself as modelling what I think, you know, is quality teaching and things like that so that they can then hopefully see a good model. (Sara)
Observes Practice	Yeah so I'll go into rooms, their classrooms which some people just go, we have a pretty open door policy here. People come in and out of my room all the time, I don't really, doesn't really faze me at all. But I'll just pop in every now and then and just see how everything's going and talk to the kids. And then I'll then speak to, speak to them, ask them about the teacher about what they were doing. And how things were going and then they generally start to say, 'oh well this student here is really struggling. What can I do?' Or this, 'I'm having behaviour issues with these students'. And then we put into place some sort of a plan I guess, to, to try and combat that. (Krissie)

As indicated in Table 2, 11 out of the 25 participants mentioned the *modelling teaching* as part of their leading practice. It is interesting that less than half the participants specifically talked about classroom-based modelling, perhaps indicating that the practice architectures or conditions within their schools (e.g., timetabling and role descriptions that emphasis managerial tasks) are constraints. Participants typically described the modelling of teaching as occurring alongside others, including the use of a co-teaching approach. Modelling of effective practice was considered as a strategy to benefit student learning, as expressed by Cameron:

It's why I got into teaching and it's something that I feel like I can do well and benefit the students, but also it sends a message to my team that 'my leader isn't just someone who is often in an office'.

Cameron noted that modelling practice also assisted him in being perceived as an active member of the teaching team who experienced the same challenges as those

he leads. Mack spoke about how he supports his teachers in the implementation of new pedagogies and resources by modelling their use. He also uses opportunities to work side by side with teachers to learn the approaches being used by each teacher, saying: 'the way I'll probably do it is to try and model it into my own teaching so that they can see me using it, but also to know my staff that are already doing certain things'. Modelling of teaching practice was also noted to occur in response to an identified need expressed by teachers or resulting from assessment data analysis.

Six participants spoke about *observing practice* in either informal or formal classroom situations. For example, Krissie (see quote in Table 3) indicated classroom observations were a regular practice for her. Rani spoke about how she uses lesson observations as the basis for discussions with beginning teachers. She also used those informal opportunities to promote teacher wellbeing, with an awareness that any negative feedback needs to be delivered in a sensitive manner. Lesson observations were also viewed as a strategy to touch base with students: 'A lot of the kids I've had before, as well, so it's nice to see them again' (Rani). Cameron commented on a very specific strategy he used to promote teacher reflection:

I did a teaching observation today, so I went down to the courts and observed one of my teachers doing outdoor PE lesson and recorded extensive notes on just what I observed and I try not to put in opinions or what I think they should do differently. But I asked for a self-reflection. And then we meet and go through their self-reflection and what I observed and I had just asked him 'has anything stood out to you through that?'.

The small number of comments relating to the observation of practice is interesting and it is unclear if the interview participants did not regularly engage in observations as part of their leadership practice. The six participants who did comment were all secondary teachers, which may imply the material-economic (e.g., time and timetabling) and social-political (e.g., the hierarchical management structure) arrangements within the secondary context may provide less opportunities for classroom observations to occur when compared to the arrangements in primary school contexts.

Collaborating and communicating

Arguably, collaboration and communication typically occur within the broader practices that MLs engage in and unsurprisingly, this practice dimension had the highest frequency when the data were coded (n = 80). All data coded within this dimension linked very specifically to the ways, the reasons, and the strategies for communication and collaboration utilised by the participants. Table 4 provides exemplar excerpts of data alongside the themes that emerged within the communicating and collaborating dimension.

Collaborating

A significant element of MLs' roles is the requirement to *develop others*. While comments related directly to the provision of professional learning are coded in the

Table 4 Collaborating and communicating data excerpts

	Theme	Excerpt
Collaborating	Develops others	So, during the collaborative planning we've been able to sort students, provide differentiated pathways obviously we're still doing the same concept but different. Two different achievement levels doing different questions, so you know, two years ago we weren't doing that at all… (Grant)
	Builds and maintains teams	So that's about bringing people together, making sure the right people are at the table, for whatever the school needs. (Bella)
	Recognises and uses others' strengths	So calling on other people is, is certainly integral in how I approach I guess some of that, facilitating some of that PL. (Krissie)
Communicating	Communicates	…it's about having conversations with staff and students about what it is that we do here and what is the character of the learners here and so that might be in visiting classrooms or talking to students in the playground. (Belinda)
	Leads informally	I think most of it is done on the run in a day-to-day kind of setting. (Sally)
	Provides and seeks feedback	…the more formal part for me is when I collect a program and I'll give them written feedback or I will go into a list and observation and we'll have a particular focus and then we'll have a debrief afterwards. (Rani)
	Translates	And the other thing I think I find most is that I'm that real middle-man between the executive and the staff. I'm – I have to pass on a lot of communication as to what's spoken at our meetings in terms of the leadership meetings to my staff so they're aware of what's happening. So communication, I think, is a huge role in Middle leadership. (Jen)

managing and facilitating dimension, data coded within this theme relates to other, sometimes informal, strategies the participants engage in to develop others in collaborative ways.

According to the participants, they develop others through co-planning teaching programs and activities, sharing of resources, and collaborative analysis of student data. For example, Maisie discussed her strategy of 'assisting teachers, sitting alongside teachers for them to analyse both formative and summative assessment sets of data, so that we can best shape the next best steps in learning', and Tim explained how his faculty meetings were highly collaborative. Words like 'us', 'we' and 'together' featured regularly in the discussions, implying high levels of collaboration.

The practices of mentoring and coaching were also discussed by participants and are included here because they involve elements of collaboration (Edwards-Groves et al., 2023). In each case, the mentoring and/or coaching was part of the leader's formal role and typically related to the support of early career teachers, although Krissie and Maisie also spoke about mentoring emerging leaders. These types of supports appeared to be highly tailored to individual needs as opposed to the provision of more formal professional learning. The breadth of expertise required to address the diversity of needs could potentially have implications for the professional learning required by the MLs, particularly those who are new to the role.

Leading teams is typically an integral element of the middle leader's role and analysis of the data provided insights into the different strategies participants employed to *build and maintain their teams*. These data provided insight into two categories of teams: teams led by MLs, and teams of MLs working together within a school. Not surprisingly, the development and nurturing of relationships featured persistently across many of the conversations, along with the notion of 'sitting with' and 'working alongside' team members. Other MLs provided opportunities for members of their teams to have a voice, developing shared understandings of educational practice. While this was a positive practice for some, Belinda found this strategy challenged her team, leading her to try and understand her teachers' motivations in order to exercise influence on their practices. Belinda's situation highlights the complexities inherent in developing functioning teams. The skills required to navigate such relationships are an expectation of MLs, yet it is unlikely that these skills are fully developed when MLs first take on their roles. This has significant implications for the continued professional learning of MLs along with the levels of support they are provided with at systemic and school levels.

Four of the participating leaders worked at a school where the building of teams formed part of their strategic plan and was mandated by the senior leadership team to improve collaboration. This plan was the result of having a new principal who was brought in to make improvements to a school that faced a significant range of site-based challenges. One of the methods employed by the school to build the capacity of the MLs was to provide formal opportunities for the MLs to meet on a weekly basis, effectively resulting in the development of a functioning middle leadership team. This formal level of support for building teams also occurred to some degree across other schools. Bella described how she works across the middle leadership team in her schools to ensure consistency and to ensure the school's goals are

met. Other participants described how they build teams with fellow MLs in informal ways due to a lack of opportunities at school level. For example, Eddie took it upon himself to identify a shared free period in the timetable where the leaders could meet and network. He describes this as a positive strategy that was mutually beneficial. Not surprisingly then, the data showed a need for MLs to have formal opportunities to meet and work with other MLs within their schools, and while this seems to be important, it was not common across school sites.

Intrinsically linked to the building and maintaining of teams is the middle leader's ability to *recognise and utilise the strengths of others* in their teams. This intentional strategy was cited by eight of the participating leaders who each had their own ways to build collaboration through the sharing of skills. For example, Sarah spoke about how she draws on the expertise of members of her team by having them share their knowledge and teaching strategies. Similarly, Mack described how he sometimes defers to the experienced members of his team, recognising their ability to enhance the collective knowledge of the group.

Aligned with previous work on trust in leadership (Edwards-Groves et al., 2016, 2021) the willingness to use others' expertise implies a trust in colleagues while building the capacity of the group, also implying a 'power with' rather than 'power over' the group. The collaboration that emerges from the sharing of expertise has, according to Pria, allowed her to show vulnerability and seek help from her team. While considered a vulnerability by Pria, the acknowledgement that being a ML does not imply expertise across all areas of teaching and learning can be viewed as a strength that results in deep collaboration.

Communicating

Eleven participants spoke specifically about general communication methods as a middle leading practice, with Sarah noting a range of communication tools she uses:

We have a team WhatsApp, that just goes constantly, particularly in online learning. So that's a form of communication. I keep really detailed minutes from any meeting we have. I regularly send out emails just to update them on whatever comes through from Exec meetings, if we're not having a meeting, and we do have regular stage meetings, so that helps with communication.

These sentiments were common across the data set, and Sarah's comment regarding the volume of communication that occurs both formally and informally highlights the constant availability of MLs beyond their formal working hours. Adding to this, Bei spoke about the value of prioritising both digital and face-to-face communications and the benefit of being able to interpret body language to assist in understanding how to assist her team members.

Informal and impromptu communications were discussed by several of the participants, demonstrating the responsive nature of MLs' work. For example, Sally discussed how she sometimes has unplanned conversations with teachers, often at times that may have been inconvenient, demonstrating the high level of interpersonal skills and empathy required of MLs. Sally's comments imply that as a ML, she puts the needs of her teachers before her own. This is also evidenced by several

participants who spoke about the importance of listening to colleagues, along with the tensions created as a result of being the conduit between the senior school leaders and teachers, as reported elsewhere in the literature (Grootenboer, 2017). Comments relating to listening reiterate the need for empathy and demonstrate how, for several of these MLs, teacher well-being is a priority.

As mentioned, the MLs reported that they engage in a significant amount of informal leadership activities and conversations as part of their day-to-day practices. Again, data that specifically mentioned *informal leading* implied high levels of empathy and responsiveness that, in some cases, expand the official role of the middle leader, as indicated by Sarah: 'a lot of what we do is informal, and I think sometimes you lead when you don't even realise you're leading. You just do things on instinct because that's just how you roll.' The participants spoke about their intentional accessibility to their teams, including practices such as strategic positioning in the staff room, for example, as described from Maisie: 'There was a very deliberate planning of where I would be positioned in the staffroom, so the whole time I have been in amongst the great body of the staff', or having casual conversations in the school playground rather than in an office. Similarly, Eddie spoke about having to physically go to colleagues rather than have them go to her office. Pria also described her efforts to be seen to be part of her team by spending time with colleagues during breaks. A commonality amongst the participants is that their informal practices appear to be conducted with the intention of strengthening relationships and building trust with colleagues (Edwards-Groves & Grootenboer, 2021).

It was striking in the data that MLs have a consistent demand on them for informal and impromptu conversations throughout the school day, illustrating the blurring of boundaries between the MLs' responsibilities for their own classroom teaching and the diverse demands placed on them as leaders that in many instances extend beyond formal role descriptions and requirements. Considering the often-limited time allocated for middle leading duties, attention to the apportioned leadership time provided to MLs along with any support offered to them may be warranted in some contexts.

An element of the conversations and other communications that participants engage in is the *provision of feedback* to colleagues. Five participants spoke specifically about ways in which they deliver feedback formally and informally. For example, Hillary described her strategy for ensuring formal feedback is appropriate and meaningful:

So if they wanted feedback on their teaching I would ask particularly what is it that they wanted me to look at or if they wanted me to look at a student what was it exactly that they wanted or processes or whatever it was, because I think, and similarly to what I was saying with the meetings, if you are on the same page of what you're looking for it's going to be a much more beneficial feedback session.

Other excerpts highlight the complexities and sensitivities around providing feedback to colleagues.

Aligning with existing literature (Grootenboer, 2018), participants discussed the requirement to *translate* directives from senior leadership to the practices of their colleagues. In some cases, the MLs have not agreed with the directives and have had to find ways to ensure initiatives are implemented successfully. However, for some

of the participants the translation between senior leadership and teaching teams is bidirectional. Two MLs spoke about how they advocate for their teams when directives present challenges. Similarly, Bei spoke about supporting her colleagues by providing feedback to the senior leadership when initiatives are not able to be implemented successfully by her team.

This section reported on findings relating to the second of three dimensions: *communicating and collaborating*. The final dimension, *managing and facilitating*, incorporates the practices of communicating and collaborating through practices relating to managerial tasks and formal activities relating to the professional learning of team members and the MLs themselves.

Managing and facilitating

Not surprisingly, management-related tasks form a significant portion of the reported middle leading practices. Data analysis revealed a range of different, yet inter-related, tasks that fall under the umbrella of management, including management of people, time, tasks, data and programs, as presented below in Table 5. In addition, several comments involved more generic administrative practices which will be explored prior to more specific management practices. Following this, data pertaining to the facilitation of professional learning will be presented.

Managing

Participants spoke about a broad range of *administrative tasks* that sometimes linked to compliance requirements and other times arose from incidental interactions with others. There was a strong sense that the multitude of administrative tasks were often overwhelming for the MLs, resulting in a need to prioritise tasks in response to continually evolving demands. Grant provides an example of this:

… it is the fleeting conversations that lead to something needing to be done. I suppose that's part of the jobs and tasks in a way that, just, you can't ignore them, you can't put them off, you've got to deal with it there and then.

Beyond describing generic administrative practices, more specific management practices emerged from the data. The participants in this study described practices that related specifically to *managing people*, including supporting teachers when student behaviour issues arise. Vera described how she deals with managing such issues:

You know, you're counsellor to your staff. They come back, they've had a bad lesson, you let them download, you offer some suggestions on how they might deal with it next time or next time you actually go into the classroom with them, you might go and see some of the students that have caused issues, so these things are things that will pop up.

In other cases, the management of people required MLs to hold team members to account, particularly in relation to compliance. System and school compliance featured heavily in participants' discussion of their management practices and they described how this management occurred throughout their working day in

Table 5 Managing and facilitating data excerpts

	Theme	Excerpt
Managing	Administrates	…behaviour, welfare, curriculum development, program supervision, PDPs for all of my team. It also involves me looking at my beginning teachers, looking at their accreditation, making sure they're on track with that. (Cameron)
	Manages people	Managing, yeah, staff is probably the biggest one. You know, are you teaching the right thing? What are you doing this for? Why are you out for prac when you should be in for theory? There's a lot managing. (Jen)
	Manages time	So I guess time and persistence and checking in, and 'how're you going with it?' And, I just, time I guess is what it comes down to. (Krissie)
	Manages tasks	…it is managing staff, managing students, articulating reasons, it's all of those wrapped together. Sometimes you don't know what the day is going to bring you. You think we're going to be having these conversations today, and then it turns into something entirely different, and you just have to flip the switch from, for example, I was going to be, you know, planning stage six with a team to now I'm dealing with an angry parent and it's about bringing the parents on board too. (Belinda)
	Manages data	I've got to know about data analysis and how do they get the data. Put the data into a way that's actually going to work for us. (Sarah)
	Manages teaching and learning programs	I do all the programming, I make sure all the … requirements are met, the scope and sequence. (Jaydene)
	Manages resources	I just try to think about, like, what's my end goal for the department and then how do I use the budget to achieve that? It can be pretty easy if as an English teacher and had to just think, OK, we just need books, like we need textbooks. We need novels. We need this, that and the other. (Joni)
Facilitating	Facilitates professional learning for others	So I lead professional learning. I'm particularly focused around pedagogy, but I see pedagogy is everything, so I try to make sure that it encompasses. I work closely with the curriculum leaders. And also leadership development of HoDs (Heads of Departments). (Grant)
	Organises professional learning for self	I'm doing my own reading and professional learning my own way, in my own time, to really upskill me. (Genna)

formal and informal, and in both individual and group situations. The reality of managing people in terms of performance was also noted by Belinda as a challenge, saying: 'and that's the reality of this job, and it's, that's the one that I think makes me, that's the one that keeps me awake at night'. Again, there appears to be great complexities regarding the management of people and the navigation of professional relationships that has implications for professional learning opportunities afforded to MLs.

Results from analysis also highlight the challenges of engaging in a multitude of practices that MLs conduct on a day-to-day basis. As a result, time constraints appear to be one of their perpetual challenges requiring the MLs to prioritise what, how and when they engage in their middle leading practices. During their interviews, six MLs spoke specifically about strategies they use to *manage time* to allow them to undertake the dual roles of teaching and leading. For example, Sarah spoke about having to schedule meetings during morning tea and lunch breaks due to her teaching load, along with sacrificing personal time when on leave. Both Sarah and Sally spoke about how they ensure their teaching preparation is complete each day prior to organising leadership tasks. Other aspects of Sarah's time management related to the substantial amount of time spent working on teaching programs as a way of influencing teaching practice, providing additional time off class for her team members and addressing each element of her middle leading role while managing competing demands.

Linked to the management of time is another element of middle leading management that emerged from the data, the *management of tasks*. Given the competing demands caused by having teaching and leading roles, careful management of tasks is critical for MLs if they are to successfully navigate their roles and responsibilities. The participants who specifically mentioned these practices indicated the need to be highly responsive to planned and unplanned tasks, as noted in the exemplar quote provided in Table 5. In most cases, the tasks they spoke about were administrative such as responding to emails, managing budgets and compliance-related record keeping. Significantly, this illustrates the sometimes low-level tasks assigned to MLs from both their teams and their leaders, leading to a need to juggle and prioritise.

Another management-related practice of MLs is the *management of data*. While this sub-theme was referred to by only three of the participants, it is clear that some MLs are tasked with analysing data and translating it for their teams and leaders, as explained by Rani: 'I analyse a lot of internal and external data and talk to teachers about that and talk to the principal about that and how we can improve student outcomes'.

The goal of improving student outcomes is also addressed through the *management of teaching and learning programs*. This common middle leading practice varied across the participants of this study. For example, Jaydene undertakes all the programming for her team, including oversight of the school scope and sequence document. Other leaders have the responsibility for overseeing programs for compliance and some oversee programs to monitor pedagogy and to address inconsistencies in teaching practice. Of note here is the varying degrees of control exercised by the MLs resulting in some teams having programs planned on their behalf, while others are led in their programming. Relatedly, some of the MLs highlighted the

associated *management of resources*, including ordering of textbooks, reading materials and equipment, to the organisation of excursions.

It is clear from the data that management-related practices are highly complex, and while they are an important element of middle leading practice, they can potentially dominate MLs' time and detract from other important practices such as the leading of teaching and the facilitation of professional learning, which will now be explored.

Facilitating

Undoubtably one of the most critical roles of MLs is to build teacher capacity and to facilitate the professional learning of those in their teams. The participants in this study provided insight into the varied strategies they use to do this, including the translation of personal professional learning for their teams, and the design and delivery of formal professional development in response to evolving needs. However, the facilitation of professional learning holds challenges for some of the leaders. Cameron said:

… one of my frustrations with some of my team was they were not willing to take that jump into that new paradigm, and you know, maths teachers. I guess in those days we were just very conservative and not willing to change. Change is really hard. Change is hard.

Similarly, Krissie also expressed disappointment that she had not experienced success due to a resistance to change from her teaching team. Given that in some school systems MLs appear to receive minimal system-provided professional learning, it is no surprise that some MLs struggled with delivering effective professional learning for their teams, particularly given that effective professional learning needs to be tailored for individual needs and is, therefore, complex.

An understanding that professional learning can take different formats is illustrated by Lana, who explained how she addresses the needs of her team by 'providing the opportunity to access who they needed at that time'. Similarly, Cameron provides a range of individualized support that has the benefit of building stronger relationships with his team: 'Could be a book. Or I'd show this app that I've found on the computer. You know, having conversation about a syllabus and talking about data'. Other methods of facilitating learning employed by the participants included mentoring and coaching, both formally and informally. Bella spoke about a learning lounge where teachers voluntarily attend sessions focused on a range of topics.

Mary, who also supported other MLs, used a coaching model that came from her own professional learning that she voluntarily undertook to improve her leadership knowledge. Another five participants also spoke about how they intentionally *organise their own professional learning* due to a desire to improve their leadership. This learning is conducted independently from participants' schools and systems, perhaps indicating a lack of appropriate system support for MLs. The format of the MLs' self-facilitated learning ranged from having external mentors to formal post-graduate study. For others, professional reading was prioritised in order to keep abreast of current research, as articulated by Pria (Table 5) and Genna, who said: 'I'm doing

my own reading and professional learning my own way, in my own time, to really upskill me' and Rani, who spoke about 'staying up to date with research'.

Discussion

The focus of this article has been to empirically outline the practices of school MLs as they lead curriculum and pedagogical development in their school sites. Here the data relied on the MLs' responses when asked 'what do you do as a middle leader?' This practice orientation meant that the research was not so much focused on what the MLs believed or thought about middle leadership, but rather what practices they undertook as a middle leader in their school site. In a general sense, analysis of the data confirmed that the self-reported practices of MLs aligned with the roles and functions articulated in the middle leading literature (e.g., Lipscombe et al., 2023). Furthermore, while the participants in this study worked across a range of different contexts, including both primary and secondary settings, as opposed to the majority of studies that focus only on secondary MLs (e.g., Gurr & Drysdale, 2013; Wattam, 2021) and had differing levels of experience, there were commonalities in their broad practices that were appropriately and meaningfully categorised within the three practice dimensions delineated by Grootenboer et al. (2017). However, while there were broad similarities within each of the dimensions, the fine-grained analysis illustrated high levels of variance and nuance with regard to individual MLs' practices. These nuances were influenced by the site-based practice architectures and provided key insights into the complexity of middle leading practice, a finding that aligns the work of Tang et al., (2022), whose literature review revealed that different contexts influence both the conceptualisation and enactment of middle leadership. Indeed, middle leading, like any practice, is enabled and constrained by local site-based conditions and arrangements and so there will always be nuances and differences between their practices as they unfold in response to the prevailing practice architectures. These findings have added to existing literature that is largely based on defining roles, responsibilities and expectations of MLs (De Nobile, 2018; Harris et al., 2019; Wattam, 2021), failing to capture the contextual nature of the role and the influence of middle leading work.

Although the study was grounded in a pre-existing three-dimensional framing of middle leading practice (see Table 1), it is important to note that these often overlapped, as noted by Tang et al., (2022) and operated as an integrated whole, hence the difficulty in data analysis of always being able to clearly delineate which single dimension was appropriate. Also, there was an apparent imbalance between the frequency for the three dimensions, with fewer references to leading and teaching, aligning with findings from literature that demonstrate a preference for management-related tasks over leadership tasks (Farchi & Tubin, 2019; Gurr, 2019) and, according to De Nobile (2020), potentially impacting the influence of MLs on school effectiveness and improvement. Although expected, due to the site-based nature of practices, there could be a range of reasons for this given the complex and multi-faceted nature of middle leading, including the simultaneous balancing of teaching and leading, the constant and various 'in-the-moment' decisions and

actions required and their backgrounds as a 'good' classroom teacher (Grootenboer, 2018). Also, data from this study indicated that MLs situated in primary schools saw that the material-economic arrangements restricted their capacity to lead teaching and learning *in classrooms*, in that they report having little time to work 'at the elbow' with their teaching team, a finding not reported elsewhere in literature due to the limited research on middle leading conducted in primary schools. This is perhaps not surprising, as a lack of time will inevitably be reported as a limiting factor in any innovation or development, and so of course, this has implications for the ways ML workloads are allocated within primary schools. However, perhaps there is also scope to consider other material-economic arrangements that shape their leading practices, including MLs seeing their teaching as a way of leading (e.g., others may come and watch them teach or team-teach) as there is unlikely to be much more time made available for the ML to be off class.

In the data it was clear that the MLs engaged in a wide range of practices to support teaching, which in turn impacts learning. The data revealed interesting variations in the ways in which MLs attempt to influence teaching practices ranging from the writing of teaching programs for teachers (taking control of programs) to working collaboratively with teachers to develop programs, hence building the capacity and agency of others. These different practices created variances in the social-political arrangements among MLs in the form of the enabling and constraining power structures influencing or being influenced by middle leaders, the teachers and the school senior leadership. When asked why they undertook these forms of practice, it was clear that many had engaged in little professional development about how to lead the development of teaching. This aligns with the argument presented by Wattam (2021), who claims explicit support of middle leaders is needed to develop the leadership capacity of middle leaders.

Another interesting but not surprising finding that highlights a gap in existing literature and ML frameworks is the extent to which informal practices formed the approach to leading that many MLs engaged in, requiring high levels of responsivity and a sense of 'leading on the run'. Although the capacity to explore this deeply in an interview is limited, there appears to be significant time assigned to incidental work that is central to, but also interrupts, both their leading and teaching and this invariably is not accounted for in role descriptions, expectations, workloads, or the newly implemented AITSL Professional Standards for Middle Leaders (Australian Institute for Teaching and School Leadership, 2024). So, while important and substantial middle leading practices are informal and/or responsive 'in the moment', the prevailing practice architectures that shape their practice do not, or perhaps cannot, acknowledge the amount of responsivity 'in the moment' practiced by MLs. Furthermore, the impact of these incidental tasks invariably require time and focussed attention, which then interrupts their own teaching, thus making it challenging for MLs to undertake their leading and teaching roles well.

Finally, and as has been implied previously, the general lack of knowledge and understanding of the nuanced practices of middle leaders, has seen systemic support for the professional learning of MLs being perceived as lacking, inappropriate, or inaccessible, aligning with findings from existing literature (eg., Bassett, 2016; Gurr & Drysdale, 2013). When asked about the practices they undertake to

develop and improve their middle leading, all the participants reported either not engaging in personal development or having to seek their own professional learning in their own time. This seems to be a serious oversight by education systems, although perhaps there are some new initiatives emerging, for example the new AITSL Standards for middle leaders, that might go part way to filling this gap. However, it will be important that any professional development and support for MLs addresses their actual practices (formal and informal) in their school sites, rather than some generic 'one-size-fits-all' approach that views all MLs as aspiring principals. Indeed, the findings here show that there are challenges for MLs when dealing with, for example, complex relationships, and, particularly those new to the role, may need to develop their practices vis-à-vis teaching and leading, collaborating and communicating, and facilitating and managing.

Conclusion

While there has been a warranted increased interest in middle leadership, there seems to have been a lag in the understandings of what MLs actually do and how they can be best supported. The relatively recent surge in research, as evidenced, for example, by the special issue of School Leadership and Management (SLAM) in 2019, is slowly providing empirically grounded insights into the complex and multifaceted practices of educational MLs and together this is providing a foundation for appropriate support and professional learning for these key people in advancing learning and teaching. Through gathering the firsthand accounts of 25 MLs, this study provides some clear insights into what they actually do on a day-to-day basis (i.e., their actual work) and this shows that if they are to be the core leaders of teaching and learning, the core business of schools, then there is a pressing need to: (1) provide them with resources, conditions and arrangements that are centred on what happens in classrooms; (2) ensure individualised and contextualised professional learning that supports their development from being only a classroom teacher to a leader of teaching and learning; and, (3) ensure support from senior leaders that is cognizant of the complex and hectic nature of their leading as they practice not in a distant office, but right in the hurly burly of the school site.

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Declarations

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